

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, September 18, 2026

1,938 words · 8 min read

RE: Vanuatu ends MV Matui search, 39 missing · ASIO warns Beijing preparing to hack power grid · US ambassador lands in Sydney after two years · Fiji declares HIV emergency · RBA says rates only back to 'sensible level'

ASX 200

8,731

-0.11%

AUD/USD

0.7128

-0.34%

NZX 50

13,739

+1.17%

NZD/USD

0.5718

-1.62%

IN THIS ISSUE [Top Stories](#) · [Overnight](#) · [Stat](#) · [AUKUS](#) · [Pacific](#) · [New Zealand](#) · [Canberra](#) · [Markets](#) · [Upcoming](#) · [The Wire](#) · [Analysis](#)

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Vanuatu ended search and rescue for the MV Matui with thirty-nine people still missing, and Prime Minister Jotham Napat has taken personal control of the Maritime Safety Authority.
- 2 ASIO Director-General Mike Burgess demanded an urgent overhaul of Australia's terror warning tiers and said China is preparing to switch off Australian power and telecommunications networks in a conflict.
- 3 Washington filled its longest-running Indo-Pacific vacancy, with the incoming ambassador landing in Sydney on Friday as Anthony Albanese flew to the United States for UN General Assembly meetings and talks with technology executives.

• TOP STORIES

US-AUSTRALIA

US ambassador arrives in Sydney after two-year vacancy

The incoming US ambassador to Australia landed in Sydney on Friday morning and will begin work in Canberra next week, almost two years after the post fell vacant. The envoy had grumbled about Australia's pet quarantine requirements during the lengthy delay. The arrival fills the most senior American diplomatic gap in the alliance since the last ambassador departed.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "Trump's envoy arrives in Australia after lengthy delay, 'grumbling' about pet quarantine"

AU-POLITICS

ASIO chief seeks new terror warning tiers, names China on grid hacking

ASIO Director-General **Mike Burgess** called for an urgent upgrade of Australia's terror warning system and said he had warned Jewish community leaders that Iran may try to assassinate them. Burgess singled out China as a major hacking risk, saying nation states are "preparing for the day that they can turn them off" in reference to power and telecommunications networks, and that defence communications would probably be targeted first.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "Low, moderate, critical: ASIO boss sounds alarm on urgent upgrade of Australia's terror warnings" · also ABC Politics

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Vanuatu ends MV Matui search with 39 missing, PM seizes safety agency

Vanuatu ended search and rescue operations for the MV Matui, which sank between Ambae and Santo, with *thirty-nine* people still missing, two confirmed dead and fourteen survivors. Government spokesperson **Kiery Manassah** said there are no reliable records of crew and passengers and that as many as fifty-five may have been aboard. Prime Minister **Jotham Napat** has taken over the Vanuatu Maritime Safety Authority, moving it under his own office.

per ABC Pacific: "Vanuatu PM takes over Maritime Safety Authority after ferry disaster"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Albanese makes cyber safety the centrepiece of UN Security Council bid

Anthony Albanese will build Australia's UN Security Council candidacy around cyber safety and online harms, the government confirmed. The prime minister will meet Ukrainian President **Volodymyr Zelensky** at the United Nations, where the two are expected to announce a bilateral security agreement. Albanese said artificial intelligence and online safety would be a major theme of the trip, which also takes in Apple's headquarters in California.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "Albanese puts cyber safety at heart of bid for UN Security Council seat"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

[Canberra weighs smart glasses ban in Commonwealth buildings, national AI standards](#) · RNZ Pacific (wire)

Canberra is considering banning smart glasses capable of covert recording from Commonwealth buildings, one strand of a technology agenda that includes national AI standards for data centres and frontier model training. Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** said he met an Anthropic official on the technology's economic opportunities and risks. Artificial intelligence will feature in the 2026 Intergenerational Report, due next week.

AU-DEFENSE

[Senate demands outside review of fatal MRH-90 Taipan crash inquiry](#) · The Australian

The Senate has called for an external review of the inquiry into the fatal MRH-90 Taipan crash, with a recommendation that the Department of Defence's handling of its own report be examined independently. The ABC reported the inquiry itself produced the recommendation for a review of the Defence report.

AU-POLITICS

[Australian public servants seek AI limits as Labor pushes faster uptake](#) · Politico (region)

Public servants are pressing for guardrails on artificial intelligence inside the bureaucracy even as the Albanese government pushes for faster adoption, Politico reported. The tension lands as ministers open consultation on national AI standards and employers gather in Canberra for a government roundtable.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[European Parliament president says Australia could follow Canada into EU associate status](#) · ABC Politics

The president of the European Parliament said Australia would be welcome to follow Canada as an EU "associate member", extending a debate Canberra began weighing earlier this week. Canadian Prime Minister **Mark Carney** has publicly promoted his own country's ambition for closer EU ties, which Donald Trump has called a hostile act.

AU-POLITICS

[Senate inquiry rejects 'youth crime wave' narrative, urges national standards](#) · ABC News

A federal inquiry has criticised what it called a "false narrative" in media reporting that Australia is "in the grip of a youth crime wave", and urged the government to legislate national minimum standards in youth justice and detention. The report puts pressure on state governments that have tightened youth bail laws.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Australian accused of murdering Thai teenager denied bail in Pattaya](#) · ABC News

Simon Peter Carman, 45, pleaded not guilty to intentional murder, concealing a corpse, destroying a corpse, and abducting a minor for indecent purposes at the Pattaya Provincial Court, in his first appearance since his arrest in late June. Prosecutors successfully opposed bail, arguing he was apprehended while preparing to leave Thailand.

• STAT OF THE DAY

53%

cut in working holiday visa numbers, growers' estimate

The Queensland Farmers Federation says Labor's 45,000 cap and ballot for second-year working holiday makers will cut numbers by more than half, hitting agriculture, hospitality and regional tourism.

ABC Politics

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · ABC NEWS

AUKUS felt 'too hard' at times, former White House official says

Former US deputy secretary of state **Kurt Campbell**, former Australian defence secretary **Greg Moriarty**, and former UK national security adviser **Sir Stephen Lovegrove** said they were content with AUKUS five years

after its announcement, while flagging continuing problems. Campbell said the pact forced Washington to confront submarine building and maintenance capacity that was "profoundly lacking".

• PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · AP

Fiji declares national HIV emergency and expands testing

Fiji has declared an HIV emergency and is expanding testing as case numbers surge, AP and the Washington Post reported. The declaration follows warnings from local health specialists that stigma and underfunding drove the outbreak, and Wellington has already issued travel advice to New Zealanders.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solomon Islands police turn to drones against transnational crime

Solomon Islands police are adopting drone technology to counter transnational crime, Islands Business reported, citing rising drug trafficking by yacht. Aerial surveillance would extend a policing reach that currently depends heavily on partner-supplied maritime assets.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji employers press government to strengthen wage-setting framework

The Fiji Council of Employers Federation wants the government to strengthen the frameworks used to set wages, Islands Business reported, raising productivity and labour-cost concerns as minimum wage settings are reviewed.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Snakebite called a 'silent crisis' in Papua New Guinea

Snakebite carries a mortality rate three times higher than malaria and tuberculosis in Papua New Guinea and accounts for most ventilator bed-days at Port Moresby hospital. **Ben Bande** of the PNG Snakebite Initiative said access in rural and remote areas is the biggest hurdle, with antivenom treatment prohibitively costly and many cases unreported.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Panguna mine attack part of a 'very complex situation', Waide says

Journalist **Scott Waide** described an attack at the Panguna mine site in Bougainville as part of a "very complex situation", on ABC Pacific's weekly Wantok segment. Panguna sits at the centre of Bougainville's post-referendum economic and autonomy negotiations with Port Moresby.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

PNG police commissioner appeals for help finding gold theft suspects

Police Commissioner **David Manning** asked the public to help locate four men wanted for questioning over a gold theft, Islands Business reported. The appeal follows the end of a six-month national gun amnesty that produced a disappointing haul of surrendered firearms.

TONGA · RNZ PACIFIC

Third boating incident in weeks raises Tonga safety concerns

A whale-watching boat carrying passengers was involved in an accident in Vava'u on Thursday, Kaniva Tonga reported, with images showing the vessel partially submerged. No loss of life was reported and the vessel's licensing status is unconfirmed. Neiafu Town Officer **Vava Lapota** said passengers were aboard. It follows the capsizing of an unlicensed boat carrying New Zealand Anglican Church delegates three weeks ago.

NAURU · AFP

Anti-immigration posts misrepresent old Australia-Nauru treaty

AFP Fact Check found social media posts circulating an old Australia-Nauru treaty and misrepresenting its terms in anti-immigration messaging.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Wellington council commits to public report five months after fatal floods

Wellington City Council has agreed to produce a public report into the 20 April flooding that killed one person and triggered a state of emergency, with one councillor apologising if the response failed. Berhampore resident **Bronwyn Croxson** said she remains out of her home, which needs raising by more than two metres at a cost covered by neither insurance nor the natural hazards commission, and wants a council buy-out scheme.

TRADE-ECONOMY · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Australian searches for New Zealand property up 190 percent in August

Australians viewing New Zealand property listings rose *190 percent* year on year in August, after a 163 percent lift in May when Australia changed its capital gains tax and negative gearing rules, Realestate.co.nz chief executive **Sarah Wood** said. Enquiries were up 54.7 percent and saved listings 44.3 percent, with Auckland, Central Otago and Canterbury drawing the most interest at an exchange rate she put at \$1.24.

NZ-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

New Zealand Parliament disrupted after swearing in the chamber

Proceedings in the New Zealand Parliament descended into disorder following swearing in the chamber, The Australian reported, seven weeks before the general election on 7 November.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Queensland growers say backpacker ballot cuts visa numbers by 53 percent

Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** has outlined a ballot system for working holiday makers seeking a second year, capped at 45,000. The Queensland Farmers Federation calculates that as a *53 percent* reduction in visa numbers, with effects across agriculture, hospitality and regional tourism. Far North Queensland mango grower **Joe Moro** was among those objecting.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Ruddock urges forcing student graduates offshore to reapply for visas

Philip Ruddock, Australia's longest-serving immigration minister, urged the Albanese government to push international university graduates out of the country and require them to reapply for visas from abroad. He warned public confidence in the integrity of the immigration system was at risk, his most pointed intervention on the debate since leaving office.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Coalition holds steady through a week of Labor backdowns and One Nation rows

Angus Taylor and the Coalition emerged from a week of Labor backdowns and One Nation controversies without damage, The Australian's Inquirer assessed. **Anthony Albanese** spent Friday defending his late mother against what he called an attack by One Nation leader **Pauline Hanson**.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

LNP executive moves against Queensland's last Liberal woman MP

Queensland's LNP executive is targeting **Angie Bell**, the state's last federal Liberal woman MP, in a preselection challenge, The Australian reported. Female representation has been a running fault line in Coalition organisational politics since the 2025 election.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

RBA tells committee rates are only back to a 'more sensible level'

Reserve Bank leaders told a parliamentary committee that interest rates are only just returning to a "more sensible level", with Governor **Michele Bullock** saying she expected higher oil prices to be short lived but did not expect inflation back at the preferred rate until late 2027. Bullock said central banks are debating whether real interest rates have shifted permanently higher.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC POLITICS

Chinese supply glut closes pioneering Western Australian abalone ranch

Rare Foods Australia, once the biggest employer in Augusta and the world's first ocean-ranched abalone operation, is winding down after accumulating losses of more than \$25 million as of June last year. Expanded output from China's farmed abalone industry has roughly halved export prices in recent years.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Anthropic's Queensland data centre lease hinges on FIRB approval

Singapore-based developer Zerra DC is spending \$30 billion on the Western Downs Digital Park at Kogan, a 725.5-hectare site 250 kilometres north-west of Brisbane, with Anthropic planning to run Claude from Building One in 2027. The lease is subject to Foreign Investment Review Board approval. Premier **David Crisafulli** says the project will lower energy costs and create jobs.

• UPCOMING

SEP
2026

Incoming US ambassador takes up post in Canberra

Restores senior American representation in the alliance after a vacancy of almost two years.

SEP
2026

Albanese at the UN General Assembly, including a meeting with Volodymyr Zelensky

Canberra expects to announce a bilateral security agreement with Ukraine and will press its Security Council candidacy on cyber safety.

SEP
2026

2026 Intergenerational Report released

The seventh long-term fiscal projection will frame the AI and productivity debate Labor is using to justify its migration settings.

SEP
2026

Vanuatu national memorial service for the MV Matui

Marks two weeks since the sinking and the first test of the Maritime Safety Authority under prime ministerial control.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set Wellington's defence and Pacific policy.

• THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

For fast defence capability, look to commercial providers

The Australian defence establishment should work with commercial suppliers to field military and dual-use capabilities in months rather than years, the piece argues, on the grounds that government procurement pathways alone cannot meet current demands.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Katherine Bennell-Pegg's ISS mission would boost Australia's standing in space

Sending **Katherine Bennell-Pegg**, Australia's first female astronaut, to the International Space Station would lift the country's standing in the space sector, the article argues.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Rethinking Kalimantan's recurring fires: a super-wicked problem

Rifky Pratama Wicaksono and **Charisma Omega Nafu** of the Crawford School ask whether Kalimantan's annually recurring fires represent policy failure or a genuinely super-wicked problem resistant to easy fixes.

LOWY INTERPRETER

Reading Abbott's Australia from abroad

The former prime minister's sweeping history of Australia doubles as a guide for how outsiders read the country, the Interpreter argues.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ABC PACIFIC

PNG churches step in to support PALM scheme workers

Mainline church leaders in Papua New Guinea are organising support for young people working in Australia under the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility scheme, following the death of a seasonal worker from Enga in Shepparton, Victoria. **Jeremiah Yambi**, president of the local PNG community, asked churches to help PALM participants.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

What's Wrong With US Pacific Islands Policy?

The piece argues that Washington's Pacific Islands engagement is measured in announcements and dollars rather than sustained presence and personal ties. Its summary line is blunt: "It's the relationships, stupid."

Argument: American Pacific policy underperforms because it is built on transactions rather than relationships.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

[Read online](#)

[Past issues](#)

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:13 AM ET

[↑ BACK TO TOP](#)

© 2026 Center for Strategic and International Studies